we made it clear that the fundamentals of our Afghan policy would not change.'

The R&AW did not forget the humiliation. In 2000, the Indian spies converged on Afghanistan with ferocity. While the Taliban took over town after town including cities in Baghlan, Takhar and Kunduz provinces, the Indian espionage network was quietly working out a strategy with Massoud to launch a counteroffensive. Sometime in October 2000, R&AW recruits in the Afghan areas of Haz-aribagh, Khajaghar and Imam Sahib helped Massoud's forces build up a massive attack on Taliban strongholds. By the end of October 2000, the R&AW revenge was complete. All the major towns that had been ruled by the Taliban were recaptured by Massoud's warriors.

'Although we had a wide network in Afghanistan, Massoud was the best asset we have ever had. When he was killed in September 2001 by Osama bin Laden's terrorists, the R&AW was working on several important missions with his forces in Kunar, Laghman and Bamiyan provinces. We airlifted him to our field hospital at Farkhor in Tajikistan but he didn't survive the deadly attack,' said Asthana.

Two days later, Osama's terrorists inflicted a massive attack against the USA, bringing down the twin towers of the World Trade Center in New York. Asthana said the CIA had sought R&AW help in tracking down the Taliban and Al-Qaeda's terror havens in Afghanistan, and the Indian agency opened its secret vaults to share whatever dossiers it had on terrorist hideouts and leaders. The CIA was categorically told that the real fountainhead of terror was Pakistan.

'The Americans refused to accept it then. It was a big mistake and they acknowledged it during our closed-door meetings in